was another sharp signal to his scattered warlords: not only the riches of his realm but also the decisions about its rule were Akbar's, and Akbar's alone.

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The chroniclers do not underscore the fact of Akbar's marriage with drumrolls. Abul Fazl, Badauni, Nizamuddin merely describe a ruler adding another 'honourable lady'[31] to his harem. Perhaps the fact of a Rajput bride entering the Mughal dynasty is remarkable only in retrospect. Akbar himself wasn't overly self-conscious about it. The match settled, he rode off to Ajmer and visited the shrine he had set out to see. On his return, he stopped for a day in Sambhar, where Raja Bihari Mal arranged a wedding in a 'most admirable manner';[32] then, making sure that Sharafuddin kept Akbar's promises to the Rajput king, the padishah returned to Agra, galloping some 300 kilometres in less than three days.

In a fascinating essay on the evolution of Rajput loyalties to the Mughal state, Norman P. Ziegler notes that a critical marker of a Rajput's identity was his '*saga*': 'those to whom he gave his daughters and/or from whom he received wives in marriage'. As was the case across the world until very recently, a marriage was not just (or even) an agreement between two people, but an alliance between families and clans – even nations. Thus, writes Ziegler, the 'term in Marwari (western Rajasthani) for both betrothal and alliance is *sagai*, a derivative of *saga*'.

Ziegler goes on to note the Rajput custom of '*sala katari*' by which a Rajput would expect gifts of land from his sister's husband. This tradition applied across religions. Ziegler offers an example from the fifteenth century, in which two scions of Jodhpur acquired land by marrying their sister to the Muslim ruler of Nagaur.[33]

Whether it was framed in terms of 'sala katari' or not, Akbar's marriage to a Kachhwaha princess did ensure that it was her father, Bihari Mal, who retained his land, and not his rival, Suja, who had formed a less rewarding alliance with Sharafuddin.

And what, meanwhile, of Bihari Mal's daughter, with whom Akbar returned to Agra in February 1562? Often misidentified as Jodha Bai when her name was Harkha, the princess is also frequently miscast as the great love of Akbar's life. It is likely that Harkha and her husband had much to